Bend Your Baseline

Why Good Habits Don't Stick, and 21 Days to Raise Your Floor

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Before You Start 00
Chapter 1: Living on the Yo-Yo 00
Chapter 2: Your Baseline 00
Chapter 3: Bend, Don't Break 00
Chapter 4: Baseline First 00
How the 21 Days Work 00
Day 0: Getting Set Up 00
Day 1: Name Your Yo-Yo 00
Day 2: Your Peace of Mind Number 00
Day 3: Your Body's Baseline 00
Day 4: Your Stress Blueprint 00
Day 5: The Three-Pillar Snapshot 00
Day 6: Look Back at the Week 00
Day 7: Pick Your Anchor 00
Day 8: Where the Money Goes 00
Day 9: Just a Little More 00
Day 10: Stress Is Data 00
Day 11: Find Your Biggest Opportunity 00
Day 12: Keep Score, Simply 00
Day 13: What You Wish You'd Known 00
Day 14: Halfway 00
Day 15: Your Next Move, Part 1: Line Them Up 00
Day 16: Your Next Move, Part 2: Your 15 Percent Moves 00
Day 17: Your Next Move, Part 3: Lock It In 00
Day 18: Hook It to Something You Already Do 00
Day 19: When You Slip 00
Day 20: Your One Page 00
Day 21: What Comes Next 00
Chapter 5: Keep Your Margin 00
Chapter 6: When the Storm Hits 00
A Final Word 00

Bonus: If You Lead Other People 00
Appendix: Trackers 00
A Note on Sources 00
About the Author 00

Bend Your Baseline: Why Good Habits Don’t Stick, and 21 Days to Raise Your Floor

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bendyourbaseline.com

Before You Start

This is a short book with a long job.

If you picked it up, there's a decent chance you've already read at least one of the good books on habits. Maybe James Clear's *Atomic Habits*, which explains how habits work better than I ever could. Maybe you underlined half of it. Maybe you started strong.

And maybe, a few months later, you looked up and found yourself right back where you started.

That's the gap this book is for. Not *how habits work*. You already know that. This book is about the part after the reading: the 21 days where you actually do something, and the months after that where you keep it.

Here's how it's built:

Part One is short. It explains why diets, budgets, and big fresh starts snap back, and what to do instead. Four chapters. You can read them in one sitting.

Part Two is the 21 days. One short chapter per day. Each one ends with a small thing to do today, usually in less time than it takes to read the chapter. Don't read ahead. Read one, do one.

Part Three is Day 22 and after: how to keep what you built, and what to do when life knocks you off track. A short bonus chapter at the end is for anyone who leads a team.

At the back you'll find simple trackers you can copy onto paper.

A free companion app. Every day in this book has a matching day in a free companion app: the same short exercise with a place

to write your answer, a breathing timer that counts for you, and a tracker for your Peace of Mind Account. There's nothing to download from an app store. It runs in your phone's web browser, and you can put an icon for it on your home screen so it opens like any other app. Day 0 walks you through setting it up in about two minutes.

To get the link, scan the code below or go to **bendyourbaseline.com/book**.



The book works fine without it. Some people like paper. Some people like having it on their phone.

One promise before we begin. Nothing in here requires you to become a different person by Friday. Every action is small on purpose. If one feels too big, shrink it. Small is the whole point.

Let's go.

PART ONE: WHY YOU SNAP BACK

Chapter 1: Living on the Yo-Yo

If you've ever gone on a diet, started an exercise program, or tried to stick to a budget, you can probably tell this story without my help.

Something makes you start. Usually it's one of three things. **Desire**: you want to be in a better place. **Disgust**: you're tired of where you are. Or, if you're married, sometimes it's the third one. **Your spouse.** Desire, disgust, or spouse. One of them gets loud enough, and you decide: *this time, I'm really going to change*.

And often, at first, it works. That's the sneaky part. The first few weeks can feel great. The weight comes off. You're fitting into old clothes again. You feel fitter, faster, stronger. Or you finally feel like you're in control of your money instead of your money controlling you.

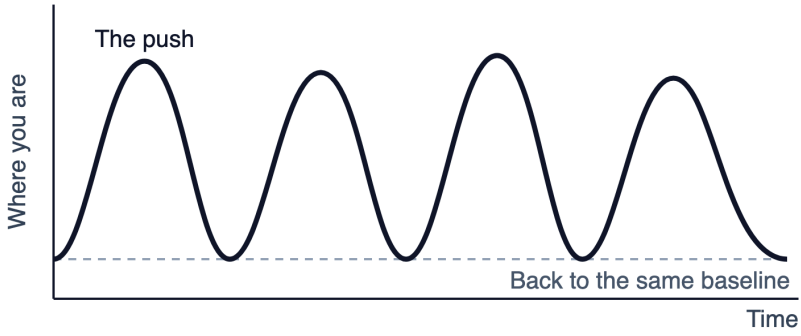
Then something happens.

Maybe it's a busy season at work. A sick kid. A vacation. A bad week that turns into a bad month. Nothing dramatic. You just stop.

And you don't notice it at first. That's the other sneaky part. There's no moment where you decide to give it all back. But three months later, six months later, you look up and realize the progress is gone. You're right back where you started.

A while later, the desire or the disgust (or the spouse) builds up again. You find a new program. Great results, early wins, and then, sure enough, something makes you stop. And back you go.

I call this **living on the yo-yo**.



The yo-yo: every push ends back at the same baseline.

Why the programs are built this way

Picture two programs side by side. One says *lose 20 pounds in two years*. The other says *lose 20 pounds in two weeks*. I know which one I'm tempted to sign up for.

We want quick results. The people who sell programs know it. That's why programs promising something big in a short window are so easy to find: six-pack abs in 30 days, your finances fixed in 60, a new you in 90.

Here's the problem. Big results in a short window usually take a very high level of intensity. The harder question is whether that level of intensity fits your ordinary life for very long. In my experience, and maybe in yours, it usually doesn't. Something makes you stop.

That's not a character flaw. A push has an end. When it ends, you tend to go back to where you were.

The copy-and-paste resolution

There's one nice thing about the yo-yo. You never have to come up with new New Year's resolutions. You can just copy and paste last year's.

I wish I could say I've never done that.

I coached Division I college distance runners for four years, back in the early '90s. In those days, one of the worst things a runner could do was subscribe to a running magazine. Every month, a new issue arrived with a new workout that was *the key*. This one. No, this one. And the runners who chased every new key never stayed on any plan long enough to find out what it could do.

We do the same thing with diets, budgets, and gym memberships. When the program stops working, we don't ask why *we* stopped. We assume we picked the wrong program. So we pick another one.

It isn't just you

Here's the part that surprised me most when I started paying attention. Organizations do this too.

If you've worked in a company for any length of time, you've seen it. Every quarter brings a new initiative, and every one is announced the same way: *"This isn't just for this quarter. This is our new direction."* A quarter or two later, a different initiative arrives, announced with the exact same sentence.

The people saying it aren't lying. They mean it every time. That's what makes it a design problem instead of a character problem. We'll come back to organizations in Part Three.

For now, the question is simple: if pushing harder isn't the answer, what is?

The answer starts with the thing you keep snapping back to.

Chapter 2: Your Baseline

Here's the idea at the center of this book: every one of us has a baseline.

Your baseline is **your natural resting state in an area of your life**. It's where you end up when you're not trying. Where your weight settles. How much you move on an ordinary Tuesday. What's in your checking account the day before payday. How tense your shoulders are at 3 p.m.

Some of it is genetics. You didn't pick your height. Genetics is part of the picture. **The part this book focuses on is what you do every day, without thinking about it.** Your defaults. Your habits.

And when I'm tired or distracted, the easier option usually wins. I'm guessing you've seen that in your own life too. That's not a moral failure. It's just what ordinary days look like.

So when a program ends, you don't fall to zero. You fall back to your baseline. The program was a push on top of your ordinary life. When the push stops, your ordinary life is still there, doing exactly what it always did.

Three baselines worth watching

In this book we'll work on three:

Money. How much cushion you have between you and the next surprise bill. Whether an unexpected expense is an *expense* or an *emergency*.

Body. How much you move, how you eat, how you sleep, on an ordinary day.

Stress. How much tension you carry around without noticing, and how fast you recover when something goes wrong.

These three don't live in separate boxes. They feed each other. Money stress keeps you up at night. Poor sleep makes every decision harder, including money decisions. Tension pushes you toward comfort food and comfort spending. The hope is that the loop can run the other direction too, so a small win in one area makes the next one a little easier.

What the baseline looks like from here

I'm going to be 60 this year. So for me, the goal isn't always pushing my baseline up. Some years the goal is just to keep it from sliding down. I don't get any faster from year to year anymore. But I stay close to the same, and that's its own kind of win.

I have a personal reason for caring about this. When my dad passed away, he weighed over 380 pounds. I think about that more than I'd like to admit. I know how quickly I could get there if I stopped paying attention to the ordinary days.

That's the real lesson of the baseline. The ordinary days win. Not the heroic ones.

Easy to do. Easy not to do.

If the answer is "small daily habits," why doesn't everybody just do that?

Two reasons.

First, small habits are slow. You do the right small thing for a month and can barely see a difference. We want the quick hit.

Second, and this is the one that gets me: **simple, easy things to do are also simple, easy things not to do.** It's such a small thing. Skipping it today won't matter. And that's true. Skipping it *today* won't matter. But skipping it today is how you get out of the habit by next week.

So the trick isn't finding a better program. The trick is working on the baseline itself: making a few small actions ordinary enough that they become your new default. The aim is that when life gets in the way (and it will), you have something small to fall back on instead of depending on the original push.

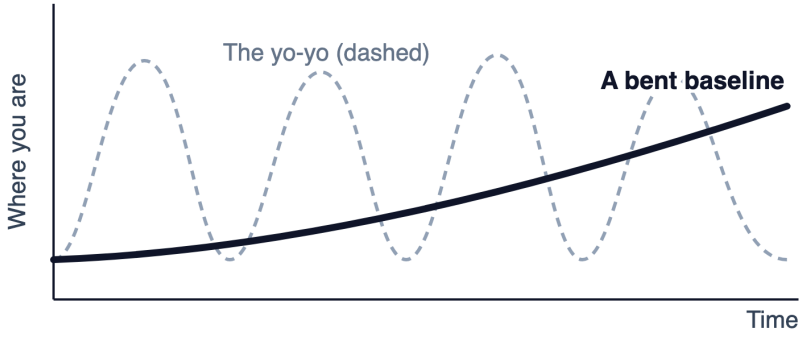
That's what it means to bend your baseline.

Chapter 3: Bend, Don’t Break

Jim Rohn put the whole idea in one line: “Success is a few simple disciplines, practiced every day.”

That’s it. That’s the strategy. A few small changes in your daily habits, repeated until they stop feeling like effort.

Draw it on a napkin and it looks like this. The yo-yo is a line that shoots up and crashes down, over and over, always coming back to the same floor. A bent baseline is different: a line that rises slowly, almost boringly, so there’s something workable to come back to when the push ends.



The napkin drawing: the yo-yo, and a baseline that bends.

Automate or habituate

I use two ways to make a small action easier to repeat.

Automate it, so it happens without you. A transfer that moves money to savings on payday. A water bottle that’s already on your

desk. A watch that chimes every hour.

Habituate it, so it happens because it's what you do. I'm not sure "habituate" is a real word. I use it all the time anyway. It means you've done it enough times, in the same spot in your day, that not doing it would feel strange.

Everything in Part Two is aimed at one of those two. If it can't be automated or habituated, it probably won't last, so we don't spend much time on it.

Margin

I have another name for what happens when you bend your baseline. I call it **building more margin**.

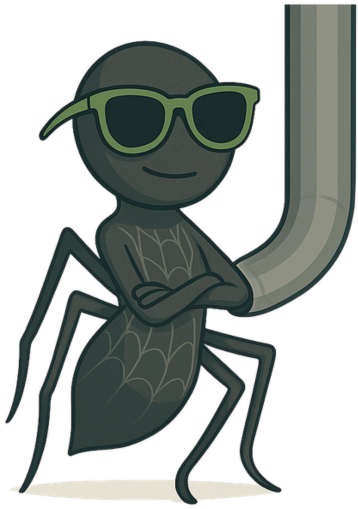
Margin is the extra capacity to handle unexpected obstacles, or to take advantage of unexpected opportunities.

A lot of us are running redlined. No extra capacity anywhere. Physically, financially, emotionally, we're right at the edge, so the smallest thing can throw off an entire day. Maybe that's just me. But I notice it most when I don't have enough margin.

You probably know the Itsy Bitsy Spider. Every time it rained, what happened to poor Itsy? Washed out. She had no margin.

Itsy has a lesser-known, smarter cousin. Her name is Bitsy. Bitsy built more margin. So when the rain comes (and the rain always comes), it doesn't wash her out.

Be like Bitsy.



Bitsy, by the water spout.

Expense or emergency

Here's the clearest example of margin I know.

Your transmission goes out. Or you're asleep during a thunderstorm and you hear that dreaded *drip, drip, drip* from the ceiling.

If you can write a check and make the problem go away, you won't like writing that check. But it's an **expense**.

If the same thing happens and you don't have the money to fix it, it's an **emergency**.

Same transmission. Same roof. The only difference is the margin you had when it happened.

That difference is what we're going to build first. And if you build it long enough, without a major storm wiping it out, something interesting happens: your cushion starts to become an **opportunity fund**. Somebody once told me the opportunity of a

lifetime comes along about once a quarter. Most of those opportunities cost something to take. Margin is what lets you say yes.

The rules of bending

Everything in the 21 days follows a few rules:

1. **Small enough to survive a bad week.** If you can't do it on your worst day, it's too big. Shrink it.
2. **One at a time.** Don't try to fix everything on Monday.
3. **Specific, not vague.** "Eat better" is a wish. "No eating after dinner" is a habit.
4. **Automated or habituated.** If it depends on remembering and wanting to, it's fragile.
5. **Direction over speed.** You're not trying to get there fast. You're trying not to go back.

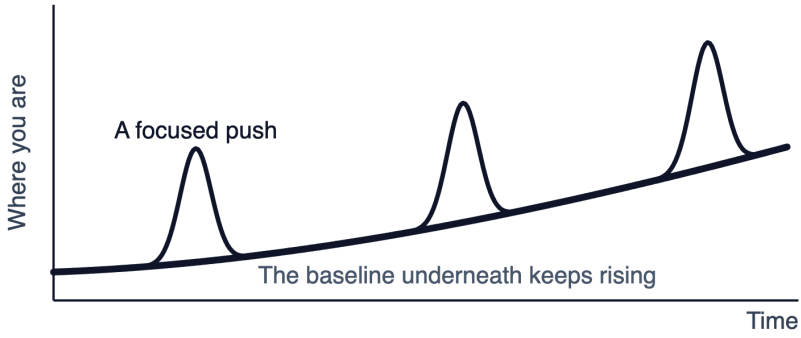
Chapter 4: Baseline First

Here's a lesson from my years coaching college distance runners that belongs in this book.

Plenty of college athletes arrive with messy baselines, because the training is so intense that they never have to build good everyday habits. The intensity carries them. Then they graduate, the intensity goes away, and five or ten years later, you couldn't always pick the former scholarship athletes out of a lineup. Some of the ones I knew ended up in worse shape than people who never played a sport. They relied on the push, and the push ended.

That's the order this book follows. **Baseline first.**

There is a time for pushing hard. Runners do it every season, and so can you: a focused 60- or 90-day stretch toward one goal. Done well, a push like that has four ingredients: **specificity** (exactly where you're starting, where you're going, and by when), the right amount of **intensity** for that gap, **recovery** built into every week, and real **rest** between pushes. I call that turbocharging, and it's a subject for its own book.



Focused pushes, with a rising baseline underneath.

But a push without a bent baseline underneath it is just another trip on the yo-yo. So everything in the 21 days that follow is about the floor, not the peak. Get the floor right, and you'll have something to stand on when you're ready to push.

PART TWO: THE 21 DAYS

How the 21 Days Work

The next 21 chapters are short on purpose. Read one a day. Do the thing at the end. Close the book.

The days come in three weeks:

Week 1: Foundation. You find your honest starting point in money, body, and stress. You won't change much this week. You'll *see* a lot.

Week 2: Momentum. You make small adjustments, about 5 to 10 percent, to each baseline. You start tracking. You learn to read your own stress like a dashboard light instead of a fire alarm.

Week 3: Activation. You pick one bigger move in each area, you build it into your routine so it doesn't depend on willpower, and you write a plan for the next 90 days.

A few ground rules:

- **You'll need something to write on.** A notebook, the notes app on your phone, the back of an envelope. Writing things down is half the work.
- **Each day has a "hard day version."** If today falls apart, do that instead. The hard day version counts.
- **Missing a day doesn't reset anything.** Just pick up where you left off. More on why in Day 19.
- **If you're using the free app**, each chapter matches that day in the app. The app adds a breathing timer and a place to track your numbers. It doesn't send reminders, so set a daily alarm on your phone for your reading time.

And a quick word about why 21 days. Twenty-one days is not magic. Research on habit formation suggests that it often takes longer, sometimes much longer, for a new behavior to feel automatic. Twenty-one days is the foundation, not the finish line. It's long enough to gather some honest numbers, practice a few small actions, and decide what you want to carry forward, and short enough that you can commit to it today.

Day 0: Getting Set Up

Before Day 1, take five minutes to set yourself up.

Pick your start date. Tomorrow is fine. A Monday is fine too, as long as it's *this* Monday and not "some Monday."

Pick your place. Where will you read each day's chapter? With morning coffee? At lunch? In the car line at school? Pick a time and place you already have every day. You're attaching this to something that already happens.

Get your notebook. Label three sections: *Money*, *Body*, *Stress*. You'll be writing in all three.

Write one sentence for each. Where are you right now? No judgment, no fixing. Just honest.

- *Money:* "I'm living paycheck to paycheck and I dread checking my balance."
- *Body:* "I sit most of the day and I'm tired by 2 p.m."
- *Stress:* "Sunday nights are rough because I'm already thinking about Monday."

That's all. You're not trying to change anything yet. You're just writing down where the starting line is.

Optional: set up the app (about two minutes)

If you'd like the 21 days on your phone too, do this once today.

1. Get the link. Go to **bendyourbaseline.com/book** on your phone (or scan the code in "Before You Start"). Enter your first

name and email. The link is sent to your inbox, and it also appears right on the page.

2. Create your account. Open the link. On the app's first screen, tap **Sign Up**. Enter your name, your email, and a password. **Leave the Invite Code box blank.** That box is only for groups.

3. Put it on your home screen. That gives you an icon you can open like your other apps.

On an iPhone: open the link in **Safari**. Tap the **Share** button (the square with an arrow pointing up). Scroll down the list and tap **Add to Home Screen**, then tap **Add**. If you don't see Add to Home Screen, scroll to the bottom of the list, tap **Edit Actions**, and add it.

On an Android phone: open the link in **Chrome**. Tap the **three dots**, then look for **Add to Home screen** or **Install app**. The wording varies by phone and browser version.

You should now have an icon on your home screen. Tap it to open the app.

4. Set a daily alarm. The app doesn't send reminders. Set a phone alarm for the time you picked for your daily reading.

Other people using the app can't see your entries.

Today: Choose your start date and your daily reading spot. Write one honest sentence each for money, body, and stress. If you'd like, set up the app.

Hard day version: Just pick the start date.

WEEK 1: FOUNDATION

Day 1: Name Your Yo-Yo

Most of us live on a yo-yo in at least one area of life. We spike, we crash, we promise to restart. Today, we stop the promising and start with the truth.

Think back over the last few years. Where have you cycled? Where have you started strong more than once and ended up back at the beginning?

For some people it's weight. For some it's the budget: three different apps, two spreadsheets, one envelope system, all abandoned. For some it's exercise, or sleep, or the promise to stop checking email at night.

Pick **one**. The one that stings a little.

Now write down your honest baseline in that area. Not where you were at your best. Not where you'll be after you get serious. Where you are *right now*, on an ordinary day.

This is harder than it sounds. We're used to describing ourselves at our peak. "I run three miles a day" (I did, for five weeks in the spring). "I'm on a budget" (I set one up in January). Your baseline is what happens when you aren't pushing.

Don't judge it. Just name it. You can't work with a baseline you refuse to look at.

A few examples of honest baselines:

- "I weigh 212. My weight has bounced between 205 and 225 for five years."

- “I have $140 in savings. It’s been under $500 for as long as I can remember.”
- “I walk about 3,000 steps a day unless I’m on a kick.”
- “I’m tense most afternoons and I don’t notice until my jaw hurts.”

Notice there’s no *should* in any of those. That’s on purpose.

Common snag: “I have more than one yo-yo”

Most of us do. Money and weight. Sleep and stress. Exercise and everything else. Pick the one that bothers you most today, not the one you think you *should* fix first. You’ll touch all three areas over the next three weeks anyway. Today is about practicing honesty in one place. Honesty is a skill, and it gets easier the second and third time.

Today: Write down one area where you’ve been living on the yo-yo, and your honest baseline in that area right now.

Hard day version: Just name the area. Fill in the number tomorrow.

Day 2: Your Peace of Mind Number

Most financial advice tells you to build an emergency fund. That sounds about as exciting as doing your taxes. So we're going to call it what it really is: a **Peace of Mind Account**.

A Peace of Mind Account is a separate pile of money with one job: to turn the next surprise from an emergency into an expense. The transmission, the roof leak, the vet bill, the week of work you miss because you're sick. It's not for vacations. It's not for sales. It's for storms.

You're not alone if you don't have one. In the Federal Reserve's 2025 survey of household finances, 63 percent of adults said they would cover a $400 emergency expense using cash, savings, or a credit card they'd pay off at the next statement. That means more than a third would not. If that's you, it isn't a personal failing. It's also fixable, one small step at a time.

Two numbers

Today you're going to write down two numbers.

Your first marker: $500. For this challenge, I use $500 as a simple first marker. If you already have some savings, the marker is adding $500 to it. If $500 doesn't fit your situation right now, choose a smaller first marker you can work toward safely. Five hundred dollars won't cover every storm, but it covers some common ones. The first win matters more than its size.

Your Peace of Mind number: one month of basics. Add up what you need each month to keep the lights on:

- Housing (rent or mortgage)
- Food (groceries, not restaurants)
- Utilities (power, water, phone, internet)
- Getting to work (car payment, gas, insurance, or transit)
- Minimum debt payments
- Anything else you truly can't skip (childcare, medications)

Round up. That's your Peace of Mind number: roughly 30 days of the essentials. Think of it as a reference point, not a rule for how much you personally should keep in savings.

Don't let the second number scare you. You don't need to start there. You start with your first marker.

Where it lives

If it makes sense for you, give this money its own place before the end of the week: a **separate** savings account, so it's easy to tell apart from everyday spending. Many banks let you open one online in a few minutes. Check for fees or minimum balances first. In my experience, money that sits in checking tends to get spent, and money that's one extra step away tends to stay put.

Give the account a nickname if your bank allows it. "Peace of Mind" works. So does "Bitsy."

Common snag: "I don't have any extra money"

Then $500 might feel like a fantasy. Start smaller. Track every dollar you spend for one week, and you'll likely find a few that surprised you. Even $5 or $10 a week is a start. The first goal isn't the size of the number. It's proving to yourself that you can move money in the right direction on purpose. A Peace of Mind Account with $20 in it is still a Peace of Mind Account.

Common snag: “I have debt. Shouldn’t I pay that first?”

Paying down debt matters, and nothing here says to stop making your required payments. Without any cushion, though, the next surprise often goes right back on a credit card. That’s why some people choose to build a small cushion while continuing their debt payments. The right order depends on your debts, interest rates, cash flow, and circumstances. If you’re unsure, talk with a qualified financial professional.

Today: Write down your first marker and your Peace of Mind number (one month of essentials).

Hard day version: Write down just your monthly housing cost. Finish the list tomorrow.

Day 3: Your Body's Baseline

Today we turn to the body. And just like with money, we start by looking, not fixing.

How much do you actually move on an ordinary day? How do you actually eat? How do you actually sleep? Most of us have a picture of ourselves that's a little rosier than reality. That's normal. It's also why programs fail. We plan from the picture instead of the baseline.

For the next seven days, track three things:

1. Movement. Daily steps if your phone or watch counts them. If not, minutes of intentional movement (walking, stairs, yard work, anything that gets you up).

2. One meal. Pick the same meal every day, say lunch, and write down what you ate. Just one meal. Just what, not how much. You're looking for patterns, not calories.

3. Sleep quality. Each morning, rate last night's sleep from 1 to 10. Don't overthink it. How rested do you feel?

That's it. Observe. Don't change anything on purpose this week. If you notice you're already moving more because you're watching, that's fine, but don't force it. We need honest numbers.

Start thinking about your one simple action

While you're watching, start thinking about one small, simple health habit you could keep for the rest of the 21 days and beyond. You'll pick it for real in Week 2. Choose something

appropriate for your health and circumstances. If you have a medical condition, an injury, a history of disordered eating, or concerns about changing how you eat or move, check with a qualified health professional first. Some ideas:

- No eating after dinner.
- Park in the farthest spot, every time.
- Take the stairs once a day. (If you work on the first floor, walk up a flight and come back down.)
- A glass of water before each meal.
- Only fruit, vegetables, or nuts for snacks between meals.
- A ten-minute walk at lunch.

Full disclosure: "no eating after dinner" is not one I've chosen for myself. Ice cream tastes best at night. Pick the one that fits *your* life.

The best one is the one so small you're a little embarrassed by it. Small is what survives a bad week.

Common snag: "Tracking makes me feel judged"

That's common, especially if you've tried tracking before as part of a diet that ended badly. Remember the rule for this week: observe, don't grade. You're not being scored. You're collecting information, the same way a doctor takes your temperature before deciding anything. If writing down a meal feels loaded, just write the time you ate it. That's data too.

Today: Start tracking movement, one meal, and sleep quality. You'll keep this up for seven days.

Hard day version: Just rate last night's sleep from 1 to 10.

Day 4: Your Stress Blueprint

Stress has a pattern, even when it feels random. Something triggers it. Your body responds. Then you recover, or you don't.

Today we start mapping that pattern. Think of it as the blueprint of your stress: where the pressure comes from, where it goes in your body, and how it drains out (or doesn't).

First, check in right now

As you read this, notice:

- Is your jaw a little clenched?
- Are your shoulders up toward your ears?
- Is your neck tight?
- Are you breathing shallowly, or holding your breath?

If you said yes to any of those, you're carrying stress in your body right now, probably without having noticed until this moment. Most of us do. I resisted breathing exercises for years. I thought they were a little weird. Then I tried it, and I realized how tense I'd been going through ordinary days. If I hadn't been so stubborn, I'd have been more relaxed for a lot more of my life.

The 4x4x4x4 breath

Here's the tool you'll use for the rest of the 21 days. It takes about two minutes.

1. **Relax first.** Start with your jaw. Let it drop. Then your neck. Then your shoulders. Then your arms.

2. **Breathe in** through your nose for a count of 4.
3. **Hold** for a count of 4.
4. **Breathe out** through your mouth for a count of 4.
5. **Hold** with your lungs empty for a count of 4.
6. **Repeat** at least four times.

If holding your breath is uncomfortable or not right for you, skip the holds and just breathe slowly. Stop if you feel lightheaded or unwell.

Try it now, before you read on.

(If you're using the app, it has a breathing timer. A circle grows for four seconds, holds for four, shrinks for four, and holds for four. It makes the counting easier.)

A note: this is a simple tool for everyday stress. If you're dealing with serious anxiety, depression, or a crisis, it's not a replacement for a doctor or counselor. Please reach out to one.

Your blueprint

For three days this week, when you notice stress, write down three things:

1. **The trigger.** What happened? (An email from your boss. A bill. Traffic. A certain meeting.)
2. **Your body's response.** Where did you feel it? (Jaw, stomach, shoulders, heart rate.)
3. **Your recovery.** How did you come down, if you did? (Walked away, scrolled your phone, snacked, stayed wound up all afternoon.)

You're not fixing anything yet. You're drawing the map.

Common snag: “It feels silly”

It might, at first. It did for me. Try it anyway for two weeks before you decide. Do it somewhere nobody’s watching if that helps, like the car before you walk into work. The point isn’t to feel peaceful and enlightened. The point is to notice the tension you’ve been carrying and let a little of it go. You may notice something the first time. You may not. Either is fine.

Common snag: “I forget to do it”

Forgetting is easy when an action doesn’t have a cue yet. You’ll set one later in the challenge. For now, try one trick: do the breath every time you sit down in your car, before you start the engine. The car becomes the reminder.

Today: Do the 4x4x4x4 breath once. Then start your stress blueprint: trigger, body response, recovery. Three entries over the next three days.

Hard day version: Just do the breath once. Four rounds.

Day 5: The Three-Pillar Snapshot

You've looked at money, body, and stress one at a time. Today, you put them side by side.

Write one sentence for each. Use numbers wherever you can. For example:

- *Money:* "I need about $3,500 a month to cover the basics, and I have $300 set aside."
- *Body:* "I average about 4,000 steps, I eat fast food for lunch three days a week, and I rate my sleep a 5."
- *Stress:* "Monday mornings and anything with my credit card statement are my big triggers. I feel it in my jaw."

Now look at the three sentences together. Do you see connections?

Maybe you do. For example, late nights on the phone may sit next to both poor sleep and online shopping. A stressful Monday morning may be the same morning you skip breakfast and grab a pastry. Money worries may show up as tension in your jaw.

That's why we look at all three at once, gently. They aren't three separate problems. They're three views of one life.

Draw an arrow between any two pillars that seem connected in your life. Write one word on each arrow saying how. ("Sleep" from Stress to Body. "Takeout" from Body to Money.)

Common snag: “My numbers are depressing”

Honest numbers often are, the first time you see them. But look at what you just did: you wrote them down. A baseline you can see is a baseline you can work with. The ones that stay invisible are the ones that run your life.

Today: Write your three-pillar snapshot, one sentence each, with numbers. Draw at least one arrow connecting two of them.

Hard day version: Write just one of the three sentences.

Day 6: Look Back at the Week

Today is a pause.

Reflection gets a bad reputation. It sounds like journaling for its own sake. But the pause is where you actually make sense of what you've been doing. Without it, a week of tracking is just a pile of numbers.

Look back over the last five days of notes. Your movement numbers. Your one meal. Your sleep scores. Your stress entries. Your Peace of Mind number.

Then write down **three things you noticed**. They can be:

- **A surprise.** "I thought I walked a lot. I average 3,200 steps."
- **A pattern.** "Every stress entry happened after 2 p.m."
- **A clearer number.** "My monthly basics are $400 more than I thought."
- **A connection.** "My worst sleep nights were the nights I ate late."

There are no wrong answers. The point is to *see* your own life a little more clearly than you did a week ago. That clarity is the point of this week.

Today: Write down three things you noticed about your baselines this week.

Hard day version: Write down one.

Day 7: Pick Your Anchor

In seven days, you've gotten more specific about where you actually are.

That's the foundation. Everything from here builds on it.

Today, pick **one number** from this week to be your anchor. It might be:

- Your Peace of Mind number.
- Your $500 first marker.
- Your average daily steps.
- Your biggest stress trigger.

Choose the one that matters most to you right now. Then write it somewhere you'll see it every day. On a sticky note on your bathroom mirror. As the lock screen on your phone. On the dashboard of your car. Taped to your computer monitor.

Why? Because what you see, you tend to think about. What you think about, you tend to act on. This is a tiny example of changing your environment instead of relying on willpower, and you'll use that idea a lot in the next two weeks.

Also, if it makes sense for you and you haven't yet: **open the separate account for your Peace of Mind money.** Even if you put just $5 in it today, open it. An account with $5 in it is a real thing. A plan to open one someday isn't.

Today: Choose your anchor number. Write it somewhere you'll see it every day. Open your Peace of Mind Account if you've decided to.

Hard day version: Write your anchor number on a sticky note. Stick it anywhere.

WEEK 2: MOMENTUM

Day 8: Where the Money Goes

Most of us spend money on autopilot. Today, we switch the autopilot off for about thirty minutes.

Pull up your last 30 days of spending. Your bank statement, your credit card statement, or both. Go line by line and sort each charge into one of three piles:

Essentials. The things you need: housing, groceries, utilities, getting to work, insurance, minimum payments.

Comfort. The small pleasures that make life better: coffee out, a streaming service you actually watch, dinner with friends. There is nothing wrong with this pile. You're not going to cut it to zero. Life without comfort is exactly the kind of high-intensity plan that snaps back.

Leaks. Money that leaves without you noticing or enjoying it. The subscription you forgot about. The app you tried once. The late fee. The membership you keep meaning to use. The "free trial" that wasn't.

Add up each pile.

Look for anything you're paying for without noticing or using. Leaks are a good place to find money for your Peace of Mind Account, because plugging them doesn't make your life any worse. You weren't using them anyway.

Before you put the list away, look at it one more time and try a version of what author James Clear calls the alien test: *if someone saw only this list, and couldn't hear any of my explanations,*

what would they say my priorities are? Your spending can show priorities your intentions don't. If the answer surprises you, that's not a reason for guilt. It's a clue about where to point your next small move.

Moving toward your first marker

For the rest of the 21 days, your job is to start moving money toward your first marker. How much depends on your situation, and any amount counts. This is the one place in the book where I'll suggest pushing a little harder for a short time, if you can. Some places to look:

- **Plug the leaks** you just found.
- **Sell something** you're not using. Electronics, tools, sporting equipment, furniture. Online marketplaces make this easy.
- **Delay a purchase** or two you were planning. Not cancel. Delay. Move that money to the account instead.
- **Redirect a windfall.** A tax refund, a bonus, a cash gift, a rebate.
- **Direct some extra earnings here**, if picking up extra work is realistic for you.

This short push is not your long-term plan. It's a quick burst to build a foundation. Once your first marker is reached, you'll switch to small, automatic amounts that you barely notice.

Common snag: "I keep spending the money I save"

That's why the account should be separate, and ideally at a different bank. Make it slightly inconvenient to get to. Don't link a debit card to it. Don't put it on the same screen as your checking account if your bank app lets you hide it. The small bit of friction

is enough to make you think twice. And when you do need it for a real storm, that's exactly what it's for.

Common snag: "I feel guilty about the Comfort pile"

Don't. A life with no small pleasures is exactly the high-intensity plan that snaps back. The goal isn't to live on rice and beans. It's to know where the money goes, plug the leaks, and choose the comforts on purpose instead of on autopilot.

Today: Sort your last 30 days of spending into Essentials, Comfort, and Leaks. Pick one leak to plug this week, and move that amount into your Peace of Mind Account. Then give your list the alien test.

Hard day version: Find one subscription you don't use and cancel it.

Day 9: Just a Little More

Look at your movement numbers from last week. What was your daily average?

Today, add 5 to 10 percent.

If you averaged 4,000 steps, aim for 4,200 to 4,400. If you moved on purpose for 10 minutes a day, aim for 11. That's it.

It sounds almost too small to bother with. That's the point. A dramatic change can leave you sore, tired, hungry, or unable to fit the plan into your day. A smaller increase is easier to fit in. Choose an increase that's appropriate for you.

Here's how people usually find the extra:

- Park farther away.
- Take the stairs for one flight.
- Walk while you're on a phone call.
- Take the long way to the bathroom at work.
- Walk around the block before you go inside at the end of the day.

Pick your one simple action

Today is also the day to choose your **one simple action** for your health, if you haven't already. You started thinking about it on Day 3. Now commit.

Write it down, and make it specific. Not "eat better." Instead:

- "No eating after 7 p.m."
- "A glass of water before every meal."

- “Only fruit or nuts for afternoon snacks, and I’ll keep them in my bag.”

Then ask yourself one question: *Could I do this during the worst week of my year?* If the answer is no, make it smaller.

Common snag: “5 percent is too small to matter”

On any single day, you’re right. But you’re not doing this for a single day. Keeping it small gives the action a better chance of fitting your life after the novelty wears off. You can always add another 5 percent next month. What you can’t do is keep a pace your life won’t support.

Today: Add 5 to 10 percent to your daily movement. Write down your one simple action and start it today.

Hard day version: Walk for two extra minutes. That counts.

Day 10: Stress Is Data

Instead of fighting your stress response, today we're going to learn from it.

Your stress response isn't broken. It's information. It's a dashboard light, not a fire alarm. When the light comes on, the useful question isn't "how do I make this stop?" It's "what is this telling me?"

Look at your stress blueprint from Week 1. Pick **one** trigger that showed up more than once, or the one that felt the worst.

Write down three things:

1. **The trigger.** Be specific. Not "work." Instead: "the Monday 9 a.m. meeting," or "opening my credit card app."
2. **Your body's response.** Where did you feel it, and how?
3. **What you needed in that moment.** This is the new part. Were you hungry? Tired? Unprepared? Did you need information you didn't have? Did you need five minutes alone? Did you need someone to say it would be okay?

That third question can change things. Sometimes a stress trigger points to something practical you need: preparation, information, rest, food, time, or help. Sometimes it doesn't. The Monday meeting might be stressful because you walk in unprepared, which is fixable with 15 minutes on Friday afternoon. Opening the credit card app might be stressful because you don't know what you'll see. The clearer picture from Day 8 may give you something concrete to work with.

Not every trigger has a fix. Some just need a better recovery. That's what the breath is for.

Common snag: "My stress is too big for this"

Sometimes it is. If your stress feels overwhelming most days, or it's affecting your sleep, your relationships, or your health, the breath is a good tool but not a complete answer. Please talk with a doctor, a counselor, or your employer's assistance program if you have one. Asking for help is a sign that you're taking your baseline seriously.

Today: Pick one trigger. Write the trigger, your body's response, and what you needed. Do the 4x4x4x4 breath at least once.

Hard day version: Do the breath once. Name the trigger in one word.

Day 11: Find Your Biggest Opportunity

In four days, you'll start three days I call **Your Next Move**: you take your biggest opportunity and make it easier to repeat. Today, you get ready.

Go back to your three-pillar snapshot from Day 5. Read it again, with everything you've learned since then.

Now ask: **in each pillar, where's the biggest opportunity for about a 15 percent improvement?**

Why 15 percent? No magic. I use it to mean noticeable but not an overhaul. It's more than the 5 percent nudge from Day 9, and nowhere near a "change everything" plan. Adjust it down if it's too much for your situation.

Some examples:

- *Money:* "I spend about $300 a month on takeout. Cutting 15 percent is about $45. That goes straight to my Peace of Mind Account."
- *Body:* "My sleep averages 5 out of 10. If I put my phone in the kitchen at 10 p.m., I think I could get to 6."
- *Stress:* "My Monday meeting ruins the whole morning. If I prep for 15 minutes on Friday, I could walk in calmer."

Don't commit to anything yet. Just circle the opportunity in each pillar. Think about it for a few days.

Today: Reread your Day 5 snapshot. Circle the biggest opportunity for a 15 percent improvement in each pillar.

Hard day version: Circle one opportunity in one pillar.

Day 12: Keep Score, Simply

You don't need a fancy system to track your progress. You need clarity. Simple tracking beats a fancy app you stop opening.

Today, set up a tracker for the rest of the challenge. Three columns: **Money**, **Body**, **Stress**. One row per day.

What goes in each column is up to you, but keep it to one quick mark or number:

- **Money:** How much you added to your Peace of Mind Account today (even $0 is a number), or your running balance.
- **Body:** Did you do your one simple action? A check mark. Or your step count.
- **Stress:** How many times you did the breath, or your end-of-day stress level from 1 to 10.

Use whatever you already use. A notebook. A note on your phone. A paper calendar on the fridge with three colored pens. (There's a tracker you can copy at the back of this book, and the app has one built in.)

The rule: **tracking should take under a minute a day.** If it takes longer, it will be the first thing you stop doing. Then you'll stop doing the thing it was tracking.

One more tip: track *actions*, not just *results*. Your weight or your balance won't move every day. But you can check off the action every day, and that's the part you control.

Common snag: “I’ve tried tracking apps before and quit”

If you’ve quit tracking apps before, complexity may have been part of it. Many ask for a lot: calories, macros, categories, streaks, badges. This tracker asks for three marks a day. If even that feels like too much, track just one pillar, the one you care about most, and add the others later.

Today: Set up your three-column tracker and fill in today’s row.

Hard day version: Put a check mark on today’s date on a calendar if you did your one simple action.

Day 13: What You Wish You'd Known

You're almost halfway through.

Today's question is a short one, but it's worth thinking about: **what's one thing you wish you'd had clarity on earlier?**

Maybe it's how much you really need each month. Maybe it's how little you were actually moving. Maybe it's what triggers your stress, or how much better you feel after a few rounds of breathing. Maybe it's how many subscriptions you were paying for.

Write it down.

Here's why this matters. The thing you wish you'd known earlier is usually the thing that was invisible to you. It was in your baseline, running quietly in the background. You couldn't fix it because you couldn't see it.

That thing is worth building a system around. If you wish you'd known your spending sooner, set up a five-minute weekly money check. If you wish you'd known how little you moved, keep a step count on your phone's home screen. If you wish you'd noticed your tension sooner, set an hourly reminder.

I have my watch set to chime every hour for exactly this reason. Without a reminder, I'd get to the end of the day and realize I'd been stressed the whole time. The chime is my cue to stop, drop my shoulders, and take a couple of breaths.

Today: Write down the one thing you wish you'd had clarity on earlier. Then write one simple way to keep it visible from now on.

Hard day version: Just write the one thing.

Day 14: Halfway

You're halfway through.

In two weeks, you've mapped your baseline in three areas of your life. You know your Peace of Mind number. You know how much you move and how you sleep. You know what sets off your stress and what it feels like in your body. You've made a few small changes. You're tracking them.

You have information now that you didn't have on Day 0.

Today, write down **three specific changes** you've noticed since Day 1. Big or small: an action, a number, or just something you noticed. Some made-up examples:

- "I have $175 in my Peace of Mind Account. I've never had a separate savings account before."
- "I'm walking about 400 more steps a day and I don't really notice."
- "I did the breath before my Monday meeting and it went better."
- "I canceled two subscriptions I forgot I had."
- "I noticed I've stopped clenching my jaw in traffic. Mostly."

Then write down **one thing you want to nail in the final seven days**. Just one.

And if you've missed a few days? Same exercise. Write down what you *have* noticed. Then pick up at the next day. There's no penalty for a missed day. The only way to fail this is to decide you've failed.

Today: Write three changes you've noticed since Day 1, and the one thing you want to nail in the last week.

Hard day version: Write one change.

WEEK 3: ACTIVATION

Day 15: Your Next Move, Part 1: Line Them Up

For the next three days, you'll take your biggest opportunity and make it easier to repeat. I call these three days **Your Next Move**: a slightly bigger step, built on the small habits you already have.

Part 1 is alignment. Before you push on any one pillar, you want to make sure the three aren't fighting each other.

Here's what fighting looks like:

- You're trying to save money, but your stress recovery is shopping. Every rough day costs you $40.
- You're trying to walk more, but you're sleeping five hours a night and too tired to move.
- You're trying to sleep better, but you lie awake worrying about money.

In each case, one pillar is pulling against another. You can push as hard as you want on the first one. The second one will keep pulling it back.

Look at your three pillars and your notes from the last two weeks. **Find one place where two of them are working against each other.** Then write down one small fix for that connection.

Examples:

- *Stress and money fighting:* "When I'm stressed, I'll take a 10-minute walk instead of opening a shopping app." (That's a body win too.)
- *Body and sleep fighting:* "Phone charges in the kitchen, not by the bed."
- *Money and stress fighting:* "I'll check my balance on Friday mornings instead of avoiding it. No surprises, less dread."

Notice that some of these fixes touch two pillars at once.

Today: Find one place where two pillars are working against each other. Write down one small fix, and start it today.

Hard day version: Just name the two pillars that fight the most.

Day 16: Your Next Move, Part 2: Your 15 Percent Moves

On Day 11, you circled the biggest opportunity for about a 15 percent improvement in each pillar. Today, you turn each one into a specific move.

For each pillar, write one move you can start right now:

- **Money:** one spending leak or comfort expense to trim by about 15 percent, with the savings going straight to your Peace of Mind Account.
- **Body:** one movement or eating adjustment about 15 percent bigger than your current baseline.
- **Stress:** one change in how you respond to your most common trigger.

Make each one pass three tests:

1. **Specific.** Could someone else tell whether you did it today? “Spend less” fails. “Pack lunch Tuesday through Thursday” passes.
2. **Small enough for a bad week.** If it only works when everything goes right, it will stop the first time things go wrong.
3. **Connected to a number.** It should move something you’re already tracking.

Some real examples:

- “Cut takeout from four nights to three. Move $45 a month to Peace of Mind, automatically.”
- “Walk 15 minutes at lunch on workdays.”
- “Four rounds of 4x4x4x4 breathing in the car before I walk into work.”

Now, following the book’s own rule of one at a time: **choose one of the three to start today.** Pick the one that also helps another pillar, or the one you’re most likely to keep. Save the other two for after Day 21, when the first one feels ordinary.

Common snag: “I can’t decide which move to pick”

Pick the one that also helps another pillar, since you’re starting just one for now. A lunchtime walk helps your body and your stress. Packing lunch helps your money and often your body. When one move helps two pillars, you get two wins for the effort of one.

Today: Write down your three 15 percent moves, one per pillar. Choose one and start it today.

Hard day version: Write down one move and start it.

Day 17: Your Next Move, Part 3: Lock It In

Here's where most plans fall apart. You've picked good moves. You're motivated. And motivation is exactly what won't last.

So today, you take the move you started yesterday and answer one question: **how will this happen without me having to want it?**

Don't make the action depend on feeling motivated. Decide what will remind you, remove a step, or make the action easier to begin on an ordinary day.

Here's how that looks in each pillar:

Money: automate it. Set up an automatic transfer from checking to your Peace of Mind Account on payday. Even a small recurring amount builds over time. If splitting direct deposit fits your situation and your employer allows it, that's another way to automate it.

Body: set up the environment. Pack your walking shoes in the car. Put the fruit on the counter and the chips on a high shelf (or don't buy them). Lay out tomorrow's workout clothes tonight. Fill a water bottle before bed and leave it by the coffee maker.

Stress: set a cue. Set a phone reminder or an hourly watch chime. Put a sticky note on your monitor with "4x4" on it. Decide that every time you sit down in your car, you'll do four rounds before you start the engine.

For your move, write down the automation, the environment change, or the cue that will make it happen. Then set it up. Today, not tomorrow. Setting up the transfer takes five minutes. Doing it "later" is how it doesn't happen.

Today: For the move you started, write down and set up one thing that makes it happen without relying on motivation.

Hard day version: Set up one thing now that makes tomorrow's move easier: a $5 transfer, or your shoes by the door.

Day 18: Hook It to Something You Already Do

You already have routines that happen every day without fail. You make coffee. You brush your teeth. You sit down at your desk. You eat lunch. You get in the car. You get into bed.

Those routines are some of the most reliable things in your life. So today, you're going to use one of them as the reminder for your new move.

Pick one routine that already happens every day, at a time that makes sense for the move you started on Day 16. Then decide on the one small action you'll do right at that point.

A few examples of how this can look:

- The coffee is brewing. That's when you do four rounds of breathing.
- You've just sat down at your desk. That's when you fill your water bottle.
- You've parked at work. That's your cue to take the stairs.
- Payday arrives. That's the day you check that your Peace of Mind transfer went through.
- You've brushed your teeth at night. The phone goes on the kitchen charger.

Keep the action under two minutes. The routine does the remembering. The new action just rides along.

If your one simple action from Day 9 doesn't have a reliable moment yet, you can give it one too. But don't add anything

brand new today. Two anchored actions are plenty.

Common snag: “My days are all different”

Then anchor to things that happen every day no matter what: waking up, the first cup of coffee, brushing your teeth, getting into bed. Even the most chaotic schedule has a few fixed points.

Today: Choose one daily routine and attach your new move to it. Write down the routine and the action.

Hard day version: Attach one round of breathing to your morning coffee (or whatever you do first every day).

Day 19: When You Slip

Plan on missing a day eventually. The useful question is what you do next.

You'll miss a day. You'll dip into your Peace of Mind Account for something that wasn't really a storm. You'll eat the whole sleeve of cookies. You'll have a week where the breath never happens.

That's not failure. That's information.

Here's something encouraging from the research on how habits form. In a well-known 2010 study from University College London, people picked a new daily behavior and tracked how automatic it felt over 12 weeks. **Missing a single day had little effect on how the habit developed.** What matters is getting back to it, not keeping a perfect streak.

So the goal isn't to never slip. The goal is to have a plan for when you do: a **reset plan**.

Writing your reset plan

Write one short paragraph that answers these questions:

1. **What's my smallest restart?** The "hard day version" of your habit, the thing so easy you can always do it. One round of breathing. A two-minute walk. Moving $5 to savings.
2. **When do I restart?** The answer is always: the very next chance. Not Monday. Not next month. Not January 1st. Next chance.

3. **What do I ask?** Not "what's wrong with me?" but "what got in the way?" Was it the schedule? The environment? Was the habit too big? Then adjust the system, not your opinion of yourself.
4. **If I used my Peace of Mind money:** was it a real storm? Then the account did what it was for. Now start refilling it with your next transfer.

Here's an example:

"When I slip, I'll do the smallest version the very next day: one round of breathing, a walk around the block, and $5 to Peace of Mind. I'll ask what got in the way and fix that. No starting over, no waiting for Monday. If I use my Peace of Mind money for a real storm, I'll bump my transfer by $10 a week until it's back."

Put your reset plan somewhere you'll find it when you need it. The back of your notebook. A note on your phone called "When I slip."

Today: Write your reset plan in one paragraph.

Hard day version: Write just your smallest restart for each pillar.

Day 20: Your One Page

Today you pull everything together onto one page: your plan for the next 90 days.

Take a single sheet of paper (or one note on your phone) and fill in the blanks:

MY BASELINE PLAN

Money - My Peace of Mind number is: $_____ - My Peace of Mind balance today is: $_____ - My automatic transfer is: $_____ every _____ - My next marker is: $_____

Body - My daily movement baseline is: _____ - My one simple action is: _____ - My 15 percent move (the one I started) is: _____

Stress - My most common trigger is: _____ - My reset routine is: _____ - My cue to use it is: _____

Anchors - When _____ happens, I _____. - When _____ happens, I _____.

When I slip: _____

That's it. One page. Everything that matters, nothing that doesn't.

Look at what's on it. Three weeks ago, you probably couldn't have filled in half these blanks. Now you can fill in every one.

Put this page somewhere you'll see it: on the fridge, in your wallet, or as a photo on your phone. Read it once a week. It's your baseline, written down.

Common snag: “Some of my blanks are still empty”

That’s fine. Fill in what you know. An honest one page with a few blanks is more useful than a complete one full of guesses. Come back to the blanks during your weekly check. They’ll fill in as you go.

Today: Fill in your one page.

Hard day version: Fill in just the three “My … is” lines you know best.

Day 21: What Comes Next

You made it. Twenty-one days.

Take a minute and look back at Day 0, when you wrote one sentence about where you were in money, body, and stress. Read those three sentences now.

Then write three new ones. Where are you *today*?

The difference may be small. That's fine. Small enough to continue is more useful here than big enough to exhaust you. You've practiced a different kind of change: smaller actions built around ordinary days.

Your next 90 days

Twenty-one days built the foundation. The next 90 are where it sets. Here's a simple plan (Part Three has more on each piece):

Days 22 to 30: Keep your margin. Don't add anything new. Just keep the habits on your one page.

Days 31 to 60: Add one thing. Once your habits feel ordinary, start one of the other 15 percent moves you designed on Day 16. Just one.

Days 61 to 90: Keep going. Keep your one page, add one more move if you're ready, and keep doing your weekly check. Pushing hard on one goal comes later, once the floor is solid.

Put a reminder on your calendar for 30, 60, and 90 days from today. At each one, reread your one page and update your numbers.

Three ways forward

On your own. Everything you need is in this book and on your one page. Part Three will help you keep going.

With the free app. If you haven't used it yet, the companion app has a "Keep Your Margin" mode for Day 22 and after, with daily check-ins to keep your habits going. It's free at **bendyourbaseline.com/book**.

With your team or group. If you lead people at work, the bonus chapter at the end looks at how the same idea applies to organizations.

One last thing. Tell someone what you did. Not to brag. Just say it out loud: "I started a Peace of Mind Account." "I walk at lunch now." Saying it out loud makes it feel more real.

Today: Write three new sentences about where you are in money, body, and stress. Set calendar reminders for 30, 60, and 90 days from now.

Hard day version: Set just the 30-day reminder.

PART THREE: DAY 22 AND AFTER

Chapter 5: Keep Your Margin

Day 22 is the most dangerous day of the whole plan.

The novelty is gone. Nobody is congratulating you. There's no new chapter waiting tomorrow morning. And the habits you built are still new enough that skipping one feels harmless.

This is where a new routine can quietly fade. Nothing dramatic has to happen. The reminders simply stop.

So for the next few weeks, your only job is to **keep your margin**. Don't add anything new. Don't start a big push. Just keep doing what's on your one page.

Boring is the goal

The first 21 days had some energy to them. Every day was a little different. From here on, it may get a little boring. Good. You don't need novelty here. You need something ordinary enough to repeat.

If you notice yourself itching to do something bigger, write it down and save it. For now, protect what you've built.

The weekly check

Once a week, pick a time you'll remember, say Sunday evening or Friday lunch, and take five minutes to:

1. **Check your Peace of Mind balance.** Did the automatic transfer go through? Is it growing?

2. **Look at your tracker.** How many days this week did you do your one simple action? Your breath? Don't grade yourself. Just notice.
3. **Read your one page.** Does anything need to change? A habit that's too big? A cue that isn't working?
4. **Pick one thing to protect next week.** The habit most likely to slip. Give it a little extra attention.

That's it. Five minutes, once a week.

Growing the Peace of Mind Account

Once you reach your first marker, keep the automatic transfer running if you can, and choose your next marker based on your own expenses, obligations, other savings, and debt. The one-month Peace of Mind number from Day 2 is one reference point, not a universal target. Some people keep building from there toward several months of essentials. Go at whatever pace your life allows.

If the storms are kind for a while, the account may start to become that opportunity fund: money that lets you say yes when something good comes along.

Adding the next thing

After about a month of keeping your margin, when your habits feel ordinary, you can add **one** new small action, such as one of the other moves you designed on Day 16. Choose it using the same rules:

- Small enough to survive your worst week.
- Specific enough that someone could tell whether you did it.
- Hooked onto a routine you already have.

One at a time. Settle one, then add another. One real risk to a good baseline isn't laziness. It's getting excited and piling on so many new habits that the whole thing collapses under its own weight.

If the app helps

The free companion app has a "Keep Your Margin" mode for exactly this stretch. It keeps a simple daily check-in going after Day 21, so you still have a place to mark each day even when the challenge is over, and it walks you through the weekly check above. If you set a daily alarm for your 21 days, keep it. You'll find it at **bendyourbaseline.com/book**.

Bringing the people you live with along

If your changes start affecting household routines, the people closest to you may notice. Sometimes they'll cheer. Sometimes they'll push back, usually without meaning to. The cookies still show up. The spontaneous dinner out still sounds fun. The "you're no fun anymore" comment still stings.

A few things tend to help:

- **Explain your why, once, calmly.** "I want a cushion so the next car repair doesn't wreck our month." "I want to have more energy after work." People support a reason more easily than a rule.
- **Start with changes that don't affect anyone else.** Your breathing. Your lunchtime walk. Your automatic transfer. Nobody has to give anything up.
- **Invite, don't recruit.** "I'm walking after dinner, want to come?" works better than "we should all be walking after dinner."

- **Don't preach.** The fastest way to lose support is to make someone feel judged for their own baseline.
- **Share the wins.** If the Peace of Mind Account makes a surprise bill easier to handle, say so.

If someone in your household wants to join you, great. Start them at Day 0. Everyone works on their own numbers. You just get to cheer each other on.

Chapter 6: When the Storm Hits

Sooner or later, a real storm will come. A job loss. A medical bill. A family crisis. A season where everything falls apart at once.

This chapter is for that season.

First: this is what the margin was for

If you have to spend your Peace of Mind money on a real storm, spend it. That's its job. The money may cover part or all of the cost, depending on the size of the storm and the balance you've built. Either way, the account didn't fail.

Don't feel guilty about using it. Feel glad you had it.

Shrink everything to the smallest version

When life gets chaotic, don't try to keep your whole one page going. Drop every habit to its hard day version:

- **Money:** Keep the automatic transfer running if you can, even if you lower it to $5. If you can't, pause it, and write down the date you'll restart it.
- **Body:** One small thing a day. A walk around the block. Water before meals. Whatever is easiest.
- **Stress:** If the breathing exercise is comfortable and useful for you, keep the smallest version going. If you're dealing with serious distress, please lean on qualified professional support rather than an exercise from a book.

The goal during a storm isn't progress. It's keeping the thread. A tiny habit that survives the storm is worth more than a big one you drop and have to rebuild from scratch.

Use your reset plan

This is what you wrote your reset plan for on Day 19. Pull it out. Read it. Do the smallest restart. Ask what got in the way. Adjust the system, not your opinion of yourself.

Refill, then rebuild

When the storm passes, rebuild in order:

1. **Refill the Peace of Mind Account** first. Bump your automatic transfer for a while if you can, even by $10 a week, until you're back where you were.
2. **Restore your one page**, one habit at a time. Start with the one that was easiest to keep.
3. **Only then** think about new habits or a sprint.

You haven't gone back to the start

Here's the thing to remember when you're in the middle of it. Even if you slip a long way, you're not starting over. You know your numbers. You have your one page. You know what works for you and what doesn't. You know how to restart small.

The aim was never to make storms harmless. It's to give yourself a few familiar actions to return to instead of rebuilding everything from zero.

A Final Word

The storms of life will keep coming. They always do.

Think about the pieces you've been practicing: a small habit, a little money set aside, a brief pause before a hard moment. Those are what this book means by bending your baseline.

They won't look like much from one day to the next. They aren't supposed to. A year from now, look back at the floor you wrote down on Day 0 and see what changed.

You can't change your destination overnight. But you can change your direction today.

Go bend your baseline.

Scott and Bitsy



Bonus: If You Lead Other People

This short chapter is for managers, business owners, HR leaders, committee chairs, and coaches. The same lens can be useful at work: organizations can live on the yo-yo too.

In many workplaces, every quarter brings a new initiative, introduced as *the new direction*, and a quarter or two later it's replaced by the next one, introduced with the same words. The wellness program. The engagement survey action plan. The safety campaign. The new software. Launch energy, a strong start, a slow fade.

The people launching them mean it every time. That's what makes it a design question, not a character question. An initiative is a push. When the push ends, what's left is the organization's baseline: what everyone does by default when nobody is driving.

Four things programs lean on

Many workplace programs lean on one or more of these. Each can be useful. Each tends to struggle when the program rests on it alone.

1. More information: "we'll train them." Sometimes information is necessary. But information alone doesn't make an action easy to begin or repeat.

2. Motivation: "we'll inspire them." Telling someone to save 15 percent when they can't cover a surprise car repair can make them feel worse, not better.

3. A tool expected to carry adoption on its own: "we'll buy a platform." Every step (download it, log in, enter your data, remember to come back) is a place to lose someone.

4. One person championing it: "we'll assign a champion." That can help, but it often depends on the struggling person raising a hand, and one person only has so much time.

A two-minute check for any initiative

1. Which of the four is it leaning on?
2. Does it wait for people to seek it out?
3. Does anyone get something manageable to *do* before being handed more to learn?
4. Could someone keep doing it during their worst week of the year?
5. What happens when the person driving it moves on?
6. Who does the work? Who bears the consequences? Who reaps the rewards? Author James Clear uses those three questions to test whether incentives line up: when they do, it's the same person. If your answers name three different people, look closely at how the initiative is set up.

The organizational version of bending the baseline looks a lot like the personal one: one small action, delivered where people already are, an action before a lesson, and a path people can always see their place on.

> ***A program is a push with an end date. A path is something you can always see your place on.***

If you lead a group, try these questions on one initiative you already have underway.

Appendix: Trackers

Copy these onto paper, or into the notes app on your phone.

The 21-Day Tracker

Day	Money (added to Peace of Mind)	Body (one simple action done?)	Stress (breaths today)
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			
15			
16			
17			
18			
19			
20			
21			

Peace of Mind Account Tracker

Week	Starting balance	Added	Used	Ending balance
1				
2				
3				
4				

My $500 first marker reached on: _____

My Peace of Mind number (one month of essentials):
$_____

Stress Blueprint

Date	Trigger	Where I felt it	What I needed	How I recovered

The Weekly Check (5 minutes)

1. Peace of Mind balance: $_____ Transfer went through? □
2. Days I did my one simple action this week: _____ of 7
3. Days I did the breath: _____ of 7
4. One thing to protect next week:
   _____

Your First 90 Days

Days 1 to 21: The challenge. One chapter a day. Build your one page.

Days 22 to 30: Keep your margin. Nothing new. Keep your one page going. Do your first weekly check.

Days 31 to 45: Settle in. Keep going. Notice which habits already feel automatic and which still take effort. Adjust the effortful ones to be smaller.

Days 46 to 60: Add one thing. If your habits feel steady, add one new small action in the pillar that needs it most. Hook it to a routine.

Days 61 to 90: Steady. Keep your margin. Do your weekly check. Add one more move only if the others feel ordinary.

Day 90: Review. Reread your Day 0 and Day 21 sentences. Write three new ones. Update your one page. Plan the next 90 days.

Checkpoint	Date	Peace of Mind balance	Movement baseline	Stress (1 to 10)
Day 0				
Day 21				
Day 30				
Day 60				
Day 90				

The 4x4x4x4 Breath

1. Relax your jaw, neck, and shoulders.
2. Breathe in through your nose for 4.
3. Hold for 4.
4. Breathe out through your mouth for 4.
5. Hold empty for 4.
6. Repeat at least four times.

A Note on Sources

I kept numbers in this book to a minimum on purpose. The two I used:

- **The $400 emergency expense.** Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, *Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2025* (May 2026). 63 percent of adults said they would cover a hypothetical $400 emergency expense exclusively with cash, savings, or a credit card paid off at the next statement.
- **Missing a day while building a habit.** Phillippa Lally, Cornelia van Jaarsveld, Henry Potts, and Jane Wardle, "How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world," *European Journal of Social Psychology* 40, no. 6 (2010): 998 to 1009. Participants chose a daily eating, drinking, or activity behavior and tracked it for 12 weeks; a single missed day had little effect on later habit formation. The study also found wide variation in how long habits took to feel automatic, which is why this book treats 21 days as a foundation rather than a finish line.

The Jim Rohn line in Chapter 3 is widely attributed to him. The idea of attaching a new habit to an existing routine (Day 18) has been described by many writers on habits; it is not original to this book. The alien test in Day 8 is adapted from an idea James Clear has shared in talks and interviews. The three incentive questions in the bonus chapter are his, from his 3-2-1 newsletter (August 24, 2023).

This book is for general education. It isn't personalized financial, medical, or mental health advice. If you have a medical condition, check with your doctor before changing your exercise or eating. If you're struggling with serious stress, anxiety, or depression, please talk with a qualified professional.

About the Author

Scott Pooch is a retirement plan consultant and educator based in Columbus, Ohio, and the founder of 401Grow. He works with business owners and their employees on the everyday habits behind money, health, and stress, and he speaks to conferences, associations, and companies on why good intentions snap back. His keynote, *Bend Your Baseline: why diets, budgets, and big initiatives snap back, and what actually holds*, is the source of this book.

Before any of that, he was a runner. He ran the 800 meters in college and later coached Division I college distance runners for four years, which is where he first learned that the easy days matter as much as the hard ones.

When he isn't speaking or working with clients, he's usually on the road in his van, trying to keep his own baseline from sliding.

Free companion app and guide:
bendyourbaseline.com/book

Speaking and group programs: bendyourbaseline.com

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